

The full source pack

Every study behind our review of the 2026 World Happiness Report chapter on social media and young people, with the sample, the method, the finding and the honest limit. Written so you can check all of it.

The report and the claim

World Happiness Report 2026. Wellbeing Research Centre, University of Oxford, with Gallup and the UN Sustainable Development Solutions Network. Published 19 March 2026. Theme: social media and wellbeing.

The editors framed the whole report as a "complex global picture," and paired the strong chapter with more cautious ones.

Chapter 3, Haidt and Rausch. Titled "Social media is harming adolescents at a scale large enough to cause changes at the population level." Framed as a product safety question: are social media platforms dangerous consumer products whose design has harmed young people. Their answer: not reasonably safe for children. Built on seven converging lines of evidence (young people's reports, adults' reports, internal corporate documents, cross sectional, longitudinal, reduction experiments, natural experiments).

The small effects evidence

Orben, A. and Przybylski, A. K. (2019). The association between adolescent well being and digital technology use. *Nature Human Behaviour*, 3, 173 to 182.

Sample: 355,358 adolescents. Method: specification curve analysis. Finding: **about 0.4 percent of variance** explained, comparable to wearing glasses or eating potatoes. Limit: cross sectional, self reported, broader than social media alone.

Vuorre, M. and Przybylski, A. K. (2024). Global well being and mental health in the internet age. *Clinical Psychological Science*.

Sample: 2,414,294 people, 168 countries, 2006 to 2021. Finding: internet access mostly positively associated with wellbeing; no population wide harm signal. Limit: associational, ecological.

Vuorre, M. and Przybylski, A. K. (2023). Facebook adoption and well being in 72 countries. *Royal Society Open Science*, 10, 221451.

Sample: 946,798 people. Finding: no evidence of population level harm from Facebook adoption. Limit: coarse country level proxy.

Odgers, C. L. (2024). Review of The Anxious Generation. *Nature*, 628, 29 to 30.

No evidence platforms are rewiring children's brains or driving an epidemic; correlation mistaken for causation. Harm concentrates in children already vulnerable offline.

Odgers, C. L. and Jensen, M. R. (2020). Adolescent mental health in the digital age. *Journal of Child Psychology and Psychiatry*, 61, 336 to 348.

Small associations, mostly unable to separate cause from effect, unlikely to be clinically significant.

Ferguson, C. J. Meta analyses of screen media and adolescent mental health (2021 and later).

Near zero average effects, below thresholds of practical significance; the recurring moral panic pattern. Limit: inclusion choices contested.

The honest nuance and the strongest case for harm

Orben, Przybylski, Blakemore and Kievit (2022). Windows of developmental sensitivity to social media. *Nature Communications*, 13, 1649.

84,011 cross sectional, 17,409 longitudinal. The negative link is strongest in windows: girls around 11 to 13, boys 14 to 15, both again around 19. The average hides real structure.

Braghieri, Levy and Makarin (2022). Social media and mental health. *American Economic Review*, 112(11), 3660 to 3693.

The staggered Facebook college rollout from 2004 as a natural experiment, about 430,000 responses. Finding: Facebook's arrival caused a real worsening in student mental health, mechanism pointing at social comparison. The strongest causal card for harm. Limit: 2004 Facebook, college students, not a young adolescent on an algorithmic feed today.

Twenge, J. M. (with Haidt and others), reanalyses of the shared datasets.

Argues pooling all screen time dilutes the signal; isolating social media and a curvilinear dose response yields larger associations, concentrated in girls; the post 2012 cohort trend is not captured by variance explained figures. The disagreement is about analytic choices on shared open data, not fabricated results.

Sunstein, C. (2026). Social media, wasting time, and product traps. *World Happiness Report 2026*, Chapter 6.

The collective action argument: individuals cannot easily quit without losing connection, and there is a negative externality on non users.

The report checking itself (its own more cautious chapters)

Children using social media under one hour a day reported the highest wellbeing of all, higher than non users.

The international evidence chapter: raising a child's sense of belonging at school from low to high improved girls' life satisfaction around four times more in the UK and Ireland, and around six times more across 47 countries, than moving social media use from high to low.

Heavy use is associated with lower wellbeing on average but highly dependent on platform, usage style, gender and family circumstances.

The live debate, for balance

Sigaud, Rausch, McClean and Haidt (2026). *Clinical Psychological Science*.

Argue the Vuorre and Przybylski studies should not be used to exonerate social media, citing over aggregation and methodological issues, and that the near zero correlation came from analytic choices that each shrank the estimate. Included so the review is fair to both sides.

Two honesty notes carried into the review

Different measurements. The 0.4 percent variance figure (how much of the spread in wellbeing tracks with use) is not the same as an attributable fraction (the share of cases a factor accounts for). Never sum or directly compare them.

Proportionality. Work estimating how much of the youth mental health burden each factor carries consistently places poverty, adverse childhood experiences and family mental health well above social media use. Exact per factor percentages vary by study and should be cited to their original source before being published as hard numbers. The direction is well supported.

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2026 World Happiness Report; where a figure could not be read from the primary document directly
it was corroborated across multiple independent sources.